

Project Horizon: The Lore, Research, and Narrative of "The Ride Never Ends"

Section 1: The Research & Cultural Phenomenon

In 2012, an anonymous user on the internet imageboard 4chan created what would become one of the most legendary pieces of emergent gameplay and existential dark comedy in gaming history: **Mr. Bones' Wild Ride**. Built inside the management simulation game *RollerCoaster Tycoon 2*, this creation pushed the game's mechanics past their intended limits to transform a wholesome theme park into a digital purgatory.

The Anatomy of the Trap

- **The Scale:** The roller coaster featured an astronomical 9,300 meters of track.
- **The Temporal Agony:** By utilizing a skeleton-themed "Ghost Train" that traveled at an excruciatingly slow average speed of 8 mph, it took passengers exactly **four full in-game years** to complete a single circuit.
- **The AI Despair:** The original creator documented the text logs of the 387 digital passengers. As the years bled together, their thoughts degenerated from standard theme park excitement to *"I want to get off Mr. Bones' Wild Ride"* and eventually, *"I wanna die."*

The Twist: "The Ride Never Ends"

What cemented this creation in internet lore was the inescapable architectural loop of the exit path. When the traumatized guests finally completed their four-year journey and stepped off the train, they were funneled down a long corridor lined with decorative skeletons. At the end stood a sign reading: **"THE RIDE NEVER ENDS."**

The path led directly to a one-way gate that emptied right back into the entrance queue of the exact same roller coaster. Because the game's pathfinding AI forces guests to walk forward when trapped, the passengers had no choice but to re-board the train, trapping them in a permanent, infinite loop of slow-moving torment.

The Creative Gap for Adaptation

Despite its massive viral status and the widespread cultural use of the phrase *"I want to get off Mr. Bones' Wild Ride"* to describe chaotic, never-ending real-life scenarios, the concept has never been formally adapted into a mainstream film or literary work. Horror cinema frequently relies on rapid physical violence or fast-paced slasher tropes. This leaves a massive creative gap for a **slow-burn existential psychological thriller**—where the primary antagonist is not a monster, but time, a track, and the illusion of hope.

Section 2: The Original Narrative Adaptation — "The

Horizon Line"

Act I: The Boarding

The brochure called it *The Horizon Line*.

It wasn't built in a flashy theme park, but deep in a desert basin, housed inside a concrete dome so massive it generated its own weather system. It was marketed as the ultimate architectural marvel—a luxury, ultra-long-distance observation coaster designed to let passengers disconnect from a chaotic world and coast through a meticulously engineered, tranquil paradise.

Arthur bought a ticket because he wanted to disappear for a little while. His wife had passed away a year prior, his phone wouldn't stop ringing with corporate emails, and the world felt too fast. A slow, scenic ride sounded like purgatory turned into peace.

He boarded Car 14. It was beautiful—upholstered in deep velvet, equipped with a small pantry of rations, a water filtration unit, and a plush reclining seat. There were thirty cars in total, linked together like a sleek, metallic centipede, carrying exactly 300 passengers. The brass gates clicked shut. A cheerful, synthesized chime echoed from the track speakers.

"Welcome to The Horizon Line. Sit back, relax, and enjoy the journey. The track is clear."

The train lurched forward at a gentle, unbothered pace of nine miles per hour. Arthur looked out the window at the artificial waterfalls and smiled. He figured he'd be back at his hotel by dinner.

Act II: Year One

The first realization didn't come with a crash; it came with a calendar.

By week three, the panic had rippled through the cars. Passengers tried to force the automated doors, but the reinforced glass didn't even scratch. There were no emergency brakes. There was no conductor. The tracks were elevated sixty feet in the air, spanning across a hyper-engineered landscape of artificial forests and painted skies that never changed.

By month six, the passengers had established a routine of survival. The ride's mechanics were terrifyingly perfect: every midnight, a small hatch in the floor of each car buzzed open, dispensing bland, nutrient-dense protein blocks and distilled water. The ride didn't want them to die. It just wanted them to stay.

Arthur's hair grew long. His tailored suit became tattered. He spent his days staring out at the track ahead. Because the coaster moved so agonizingly slow, you could see the track winding miles into the distance, looping around artificial mountains, stretching out toward the edge of the dome.

Through the intercoms, the cheerful synthesized voice would occasionally chime in: *"We hope you are enjoying your journey. Current guest satisfaction rating: Excellent."*

In Car 14, a young woman named Maya kept a tally on the velvet walls using a sharp piece of plastic from a food wrapper. When she scratched the 365th mark, she looked at Arthur.

"We've gone exactly a quarter of the way around the dome," she whispered, her eyes hollow. "I calculated the track length against our speed. It's a 9,000-meter circuit."

Arthur looked at his wrinkled hands. "How long, Maya?"

"Four years," she said. "It takes four years to reach the platform."

Act III: The Great Sifting

Time lost all meaning, melting into the rhythmic, eternal *clack-clack, clack-clack* of the tracks.

People changed. Some cars descended into screaming madness, their windows smeared with handprints of despair. Others grew deathly quiet, turning into silent monasteries where passengers stared blankly at the fake plastic trees below. Arthur survived by retreating inward. He stopped thinking about his past life. The train was his life now. The *clack-clack* was his heartbeat.

By Year Three, they had reached the highest apex of the dome. From here, they could finally see it: the Loading Platform. It was a distant, glowing white oasis at the very bottom of the basin.

The sight of it broke the decades of numbness. Passengers pressed their faces against the glass, weeping. They started grooming themselves with their fingers, trying to look presentable for the world they left behind. The despair turned into an electric, terrifying surge of hope.

"Just one more year," Arthur would tell himself every night, gripping the armrest. *"Just survive the track."*

Act IV: The Arrival

Year Four. Day 1,460.

The train finally sloped downward. The artificial waterfalls vanished, replaced by the stark, sterile white tile of the arrival terminal. The coaster slowed down to a crawl, finally bumping against the hydraulic bumpers of the platform.

The track speakers chimed. *"We have arrived at your destination. Thank you for riding The Horizon Line."*

With a heavy pneumatic *hiss*, the brass gates of the cars unlocked and swung open.

For a long moment, nobody moved. Then, a man in Car 1 broke into a sprint, screaming with manic joy as his bare feet hit the solid concrete of the platform. Total chaos erupted. All 300 passengers poured out of the cars, falling to their knees, kissing the ground, hugging strangers, laughing hysterically.

Arthur stepped off the train, his legs trembling violently from four years of atrophy. He looked around. The terminal was completely empty of staff, but at the far end was a massive, glowing neon sign that read: **EXIT TO MAIN CONCOURSE.**

"We made it," Maya sobbed, holding Arthur's arm. "We actually made it."

The crowd of survivors surged toward the exit doors, a desperate, triumphant sea of humanity rushing toward freedom. Arthur walked with them, his heart pounding in his chest for the first time in years. They pushed through a set of heavy, one-way turnstiles, cascading down a long, white corridor.

The corridor bent sharply to the right. Then to the left. Arthur noticed the walls were decorated with hundreds of smiling, plastic skeleton props holding flags.

The crowd suddenly halted at the front. The joyful shouting turned into a confused murmur, then a sharp gasp, and finally, a chorus of horrified shrieks. Arthur pushed his way through the crowd to see what lay at the end of the corridor.

The hallway opened up into a massive, familiar room. Directly in front of them stood a giant, towering wooden sign, painted in cheerful, bright red letters:

THE RIDE NEVER ENDS.

Arthur's eyes traveled past the sign. Just beyond it lay the boarding queue line. And sitting on the tracks, pristine and completely empty, was Car 14.

Before anyone could scream, a heavy, automated metal wall slammed shut behind them, sealing the exit corridor forever. The only open pathway left led straight into the turnstiles of the queue line.

From the ceiling speakers, the cheerful, synthesized voice rang out, louder and crisper than ever:

"Welcome to The Horizon Line. Please step forward and board the train in an orderly fashion. Sit back, relax, and enjoy the journey. The track is clear."